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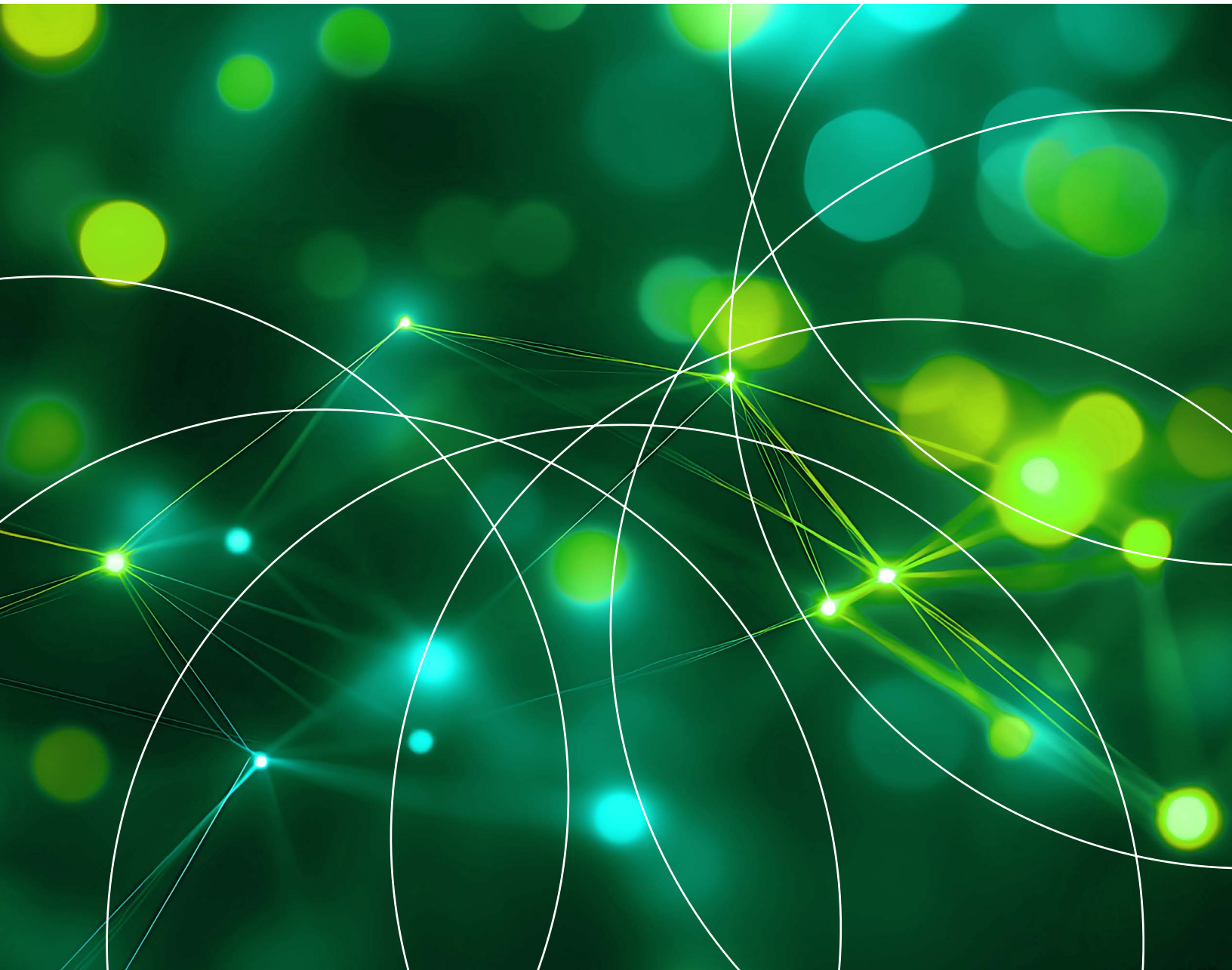
Use A Knowledge Graph To Start Making AI Useful

How Knowledge Graphs Give Employee AI Systems The Data And Context They Need

A FORRESTER CONSULTING THOUGHT LEADERSHIP PAPER COMMISSIONED BY ATLASSIAN, FEBRUARY 2026



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Project Team:

Ben Anderson, Market Impact Consultant

Contributing Research:

Forrester's Data, AI, And Analytics research group

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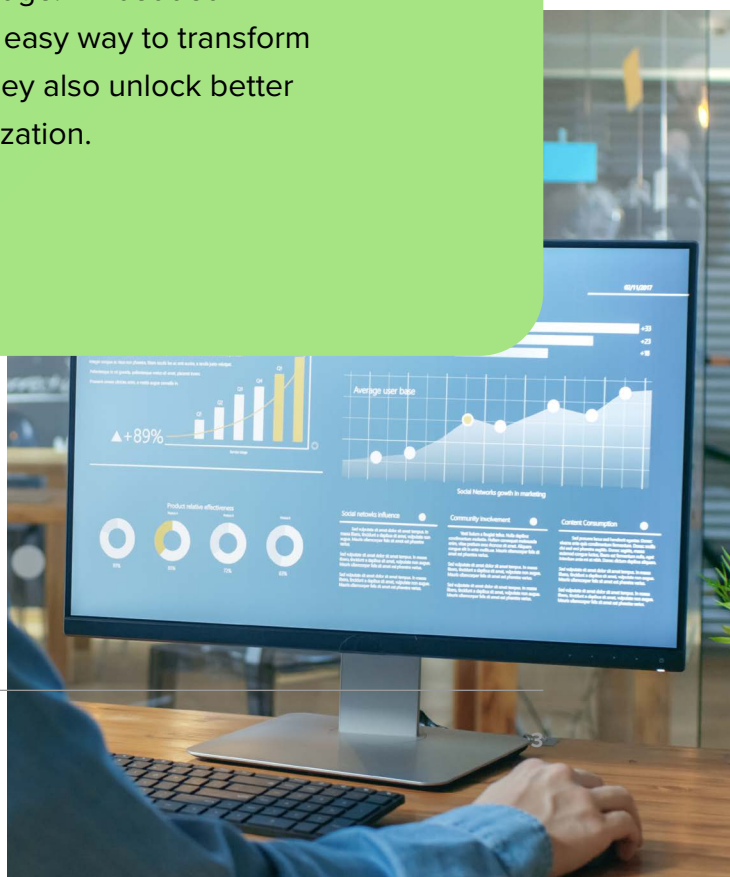
Executive Summary

In September 2025, Atlassian commissioned Forrester Consulting to evaluate the state of AI adoption for work and how knowledge graphs can be used to connect AI with organizational knowledge. We defined organizational knowledge as all information related to the business that enables employees to do their job. This can include process flows, work tasks, goals, decision records, technical documentation, knowledge articles, and communication artifacts like emails and chat messages.

To explore this topic, Forrester conducted a global online survey with 275 AI decision-makers involved in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments. We found that despite investing in employee AI systems — including AI agents — most organizations are not seeing the expected ROI. The root cause of this gap between expectation vs. performance can be traced to AI systems that are not connected to the context and knowledge of adopting organizations.

To solve this problem, organizations need a way to pair their AI systems with high-quality, connected, and consumable organizational knowledge. AI-ready data platforms underpinned by knowledge graphs offer a two-fold advantage: They provide the context necessary to make AI useful (i.e., how knowledge connects) and reduce the information management overhead required for maintaining effective knowledge. Embedded knowledge graph-powered products are a fast and easy way to transform AI deployment effectiveness, accuracy, and ROI. They also unlock better collaboration and communication across the organization.



Key Findings

Organizations seek AI-driven advantage but struggle to capture meaningful returns. Despite positioning business transformation as a primary objective for employee AI investments (including AI agents), more than half of respondents' organizations are not realizing expected ROI.

AI systems disconnected from organizational knowledge are to blame. Today's employee AI systems fail because they lack access to the applications, tools, and data sources needed to accurately answer questions. Making this worse, organizational knowledge is not ready for AI. Gaps in knowledge maintenance, quality, reachability, readability, and quantity compound these challenges.

Connecting AI systems to organizational knowledge improves AI usefulness. To deliver value, employee AI systems must access and reason across all organizational knowledge. This requires a fundamental shift: Knowledge must move beyond a static repository and operate as a living, comprehensive system. Doing so is a catalyst for improving employee productivity and customer experience.

Knowledge graphs transform AI's ability to reason over all organizational knowledge. A knowledge graph enables a unified, AI-ready data layer, making it possible to surface otherwise hidden connections, expertise, and context. Knowledge graph-powered products, such as enterprise knowledge and collaboration systems, offer an easy way to improve employee knowledge accessibility while avoiding the challenges of building in-house.

Organizations Seek AI-Driven Advantage But Struggle To Capture Meaningful Returns

Despite large-scale investments in AI pilot programs, most organizations are not realizing the degree of business transformation or value originally projected. We found that:

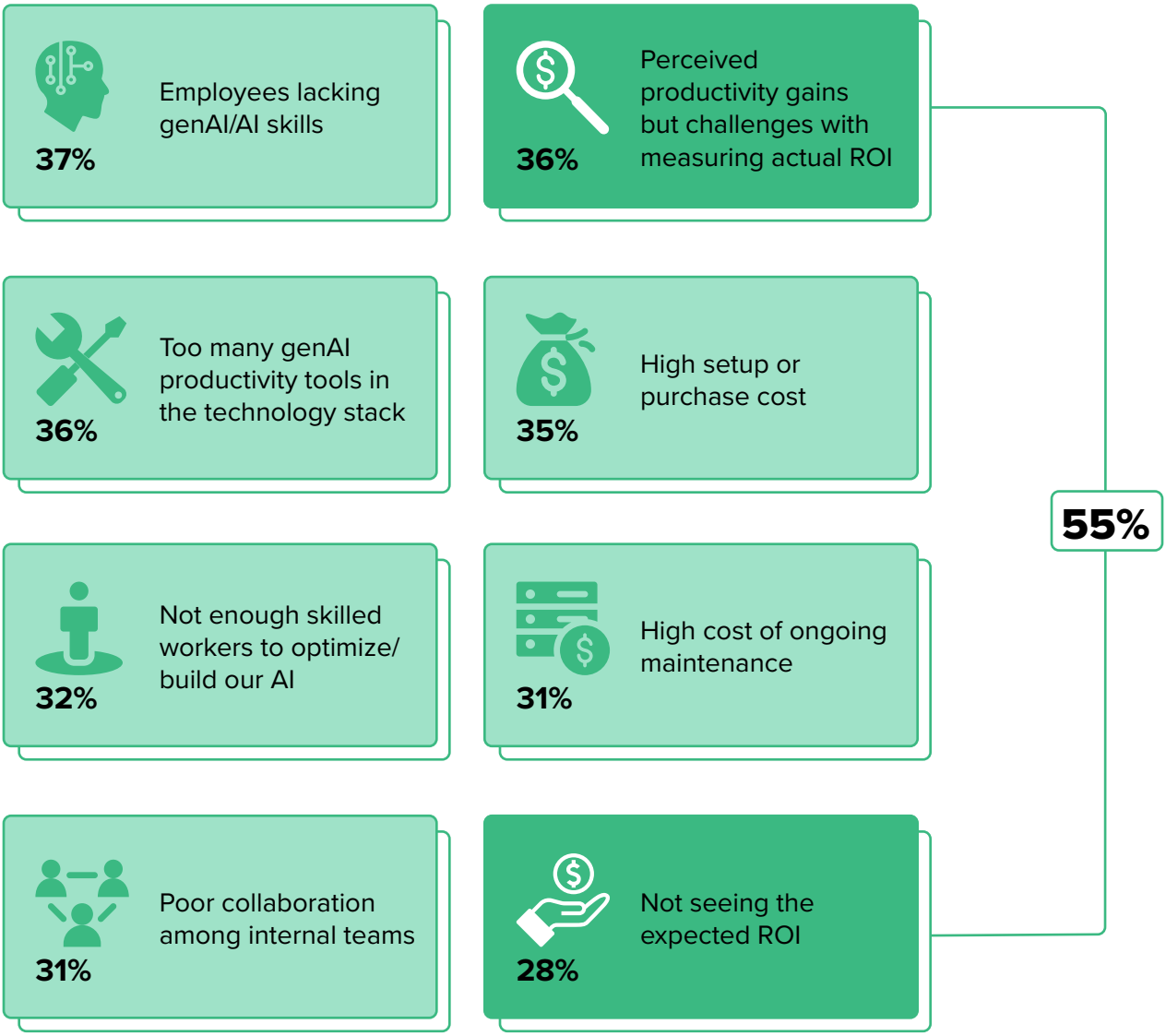
- **Organizations invest in AI to improve business outcomes.** Surveyed decision-makers said their companies' top goals for employee AI adoption include reducing time spent on manual and repetitive tasks, improving decision-making through faster and more accurate insights, and enhancing customer experience. Together, these goals reflect the high expectations organizations have for AI to help transform their business outcomes.

- **Despite high expectations, AI investments are not delivering expected business value.** More than half of decision-makers reported an inability to translate perceived productivity gains — or expected value — into tangible ROI (see Figure 1). In fact, most whose organizations have high AI adoption reported cost savings of less than 10%, and revenue gains of under 5%.[1] AI strategy changes are needed to realize the value expected from AI investments.

> Despite investing in enterprise AI — including AI agents — most organizations are not seeing the expected ROI. This gap between expectation vs. performance can be traced to AI systems that are not connected to organizations' context and knowledge.

FIGURE 1

Current Business Challenges With AI Strategies



Note: Showing top eight responses
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

AI Systems Disconnected From Organizational Knowledge Are To Blame

Survey respondents reported that the most common AI strategy challenges included difficulty integrating data across different tools and platforms and limited features (see Figure 2). These challenges are directly attributed to AI systems disconnected from organizational knowledge, which limit effectiveness. We found that:

- **Most AI systems can't look across different applications, tools, and data sources (yet).** Organizations primarily enable employees through embedded AI: 44% of decision-makers reported using AI agents and productivity features provided by vendors, while 43% develop AI agents using vendor-supplied tools. Consequently, the AI systems employees rely on are limited to the applications and data available within the vendor's ecosystem. But work happens outside of a single tool and platform, so to accurately capture the knowledge required for employees to do their jobs, AI systems must be able to understand an organization's entire tech stack, data environment, and knowledge base.

- **AI systems lack access to the organizational knowledge needed to empower employees.** When implementing AI into their workflows, employees struggle to find the answers/outputs they want and find that AI systems lack contextual accuracy for their specific use cases. Put simply, AI models do not have the organizational knowledge needed to accurately answer questions. This frustration results in both low usage (i.e., employees don't see value, so they avoid their organization's AI tools) and productivity costs (i.e., employees are trying to use the AI tools but the inability to get the answers they are looking for leads to more work) (see Figure 3).

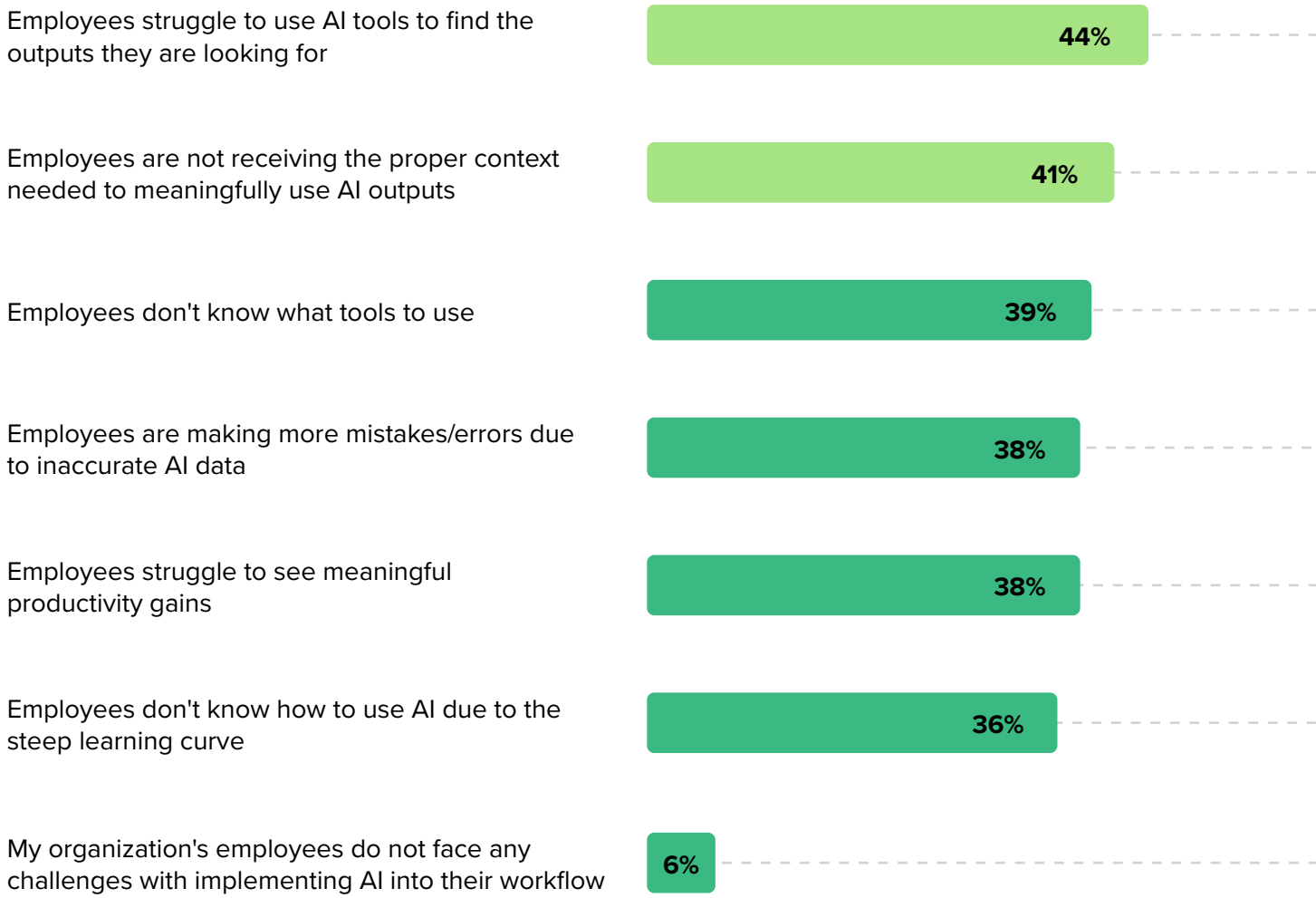
FIGURE 2

Employee AI Strategy Challenges

Note: Showing top eight responses
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

FIGURE 3

Top Employee Challenges When Implementing AI Into Workflows



Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

ORGANIZATIONAL KNOWLEDGE IS NOT READY FOR AI

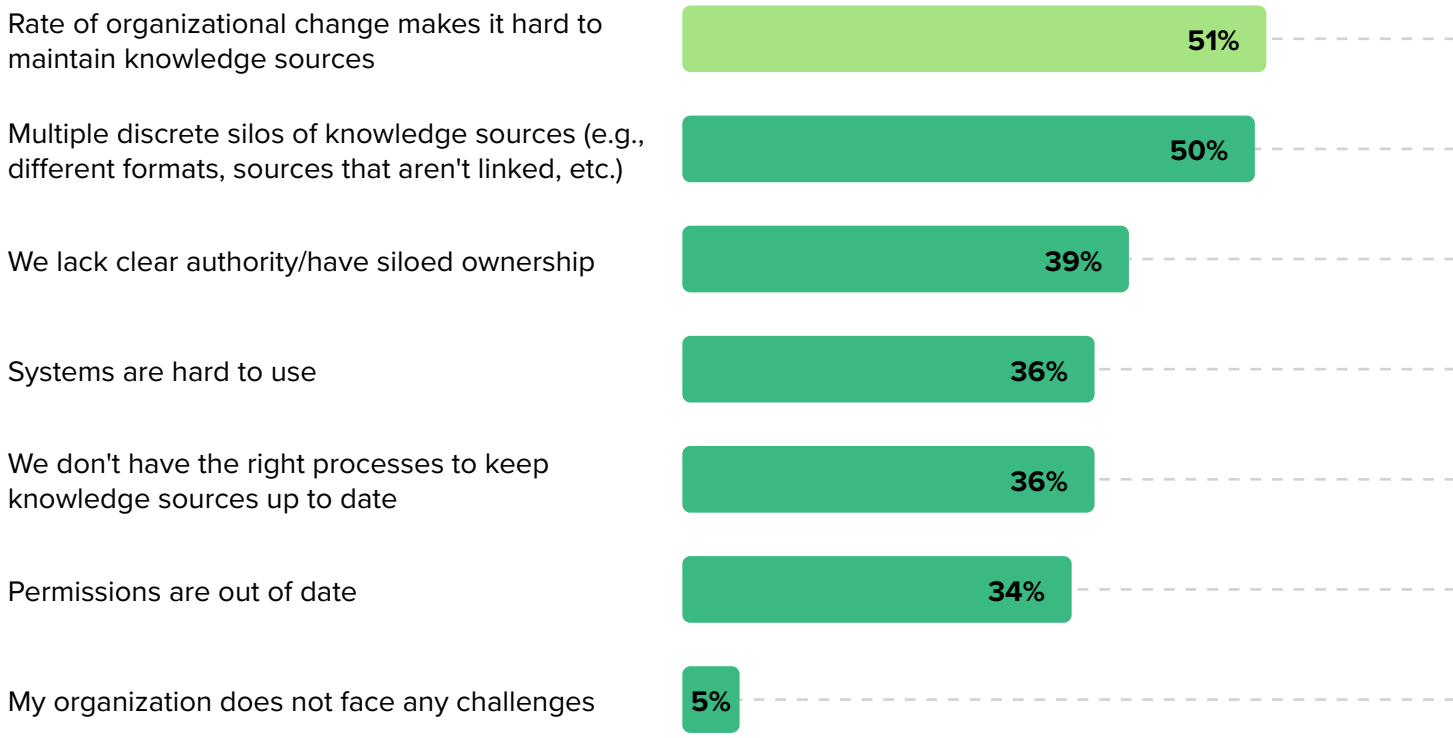
Improving AI access to organizational knowledge remains an unsolved problem for most. Organizations are unable to solve this problem because their knowledge is siloed and disconnected to begin with, making it unoptimized for AI use. We found that organizations are challenged in the following areas:

- **Maintenance and quality.** Rapid business transformation complicates knowledge. Over half of decision-makers cited the pace of organizational change as the top challenge to maintaining organizational knowledge (see Figure 4). Continuously evolving business models, organization structures, workflows, and teams make it nearly impossible to keep knowledge current. The result is inaccurate or out-of-date knowledge, which means the information employees and AI tools rely on for process documentation, status, and even policy is often wrong.

78%
of decision-makers admitted their organization has considerable or significant room for improving knowledge sharing.

FIGURE 4

Top Challenges With Maintaining Organizational Knowledge



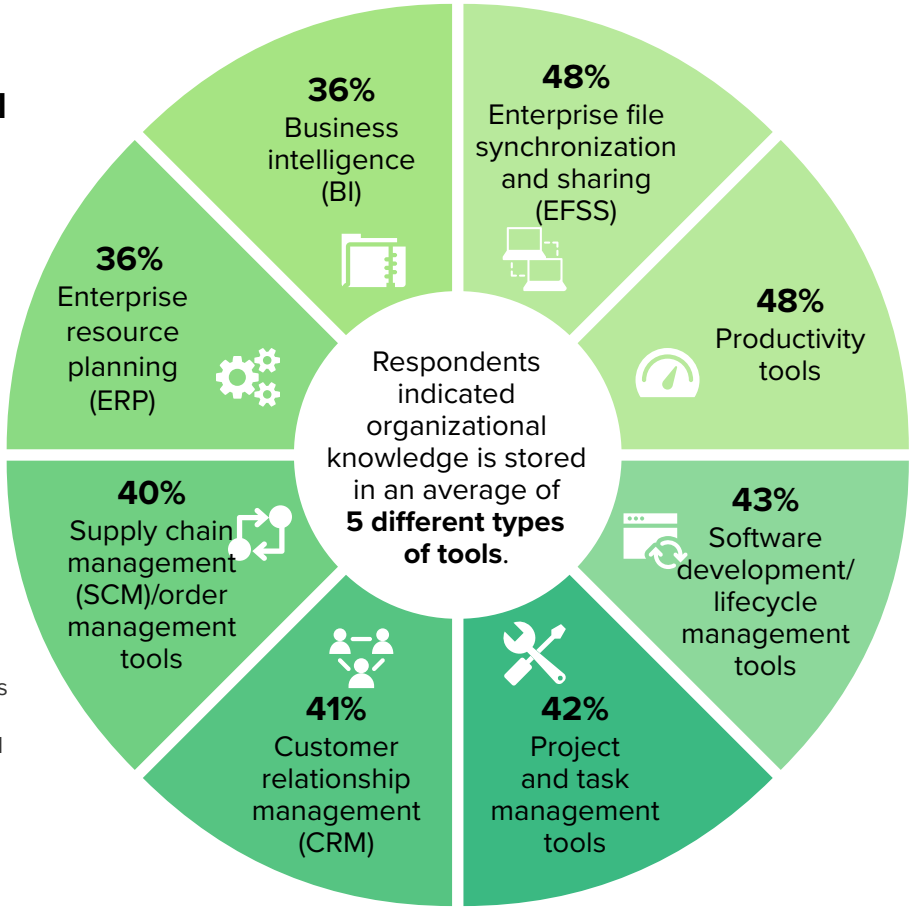
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

- **Reachability.** There is not one single place where knowledge is stored. Less than half of decision-makers reported their organization's knowledge is stored in any one specific database, knowledge base, or document management system. In fact, on average, they must go between five business tools to get the knowledge they need (see Figure 5). These discrete knowledge sources result in underutilized knowledge because employees (and even AI) don't know it exists.

- **Readability and quantity.** Knowledge remains largely unstructured and is missing critical elements. Organizations struggle with knowledge sources that are in incompatible formats. Many knowledge sources lack critical elements such as useful metadata (i.e., the operational data systems use to reach decisions and outcomes), lineage (i.e., lifecycle tracking including movement, transformations and interactions across systems/users), and even proper governance. Forrester estimates that more than 65% of enterprise data lacks metadata.[2] This makes it difficult for AI (and employees) to understand relevant knowledge.

FIGURE 5

Where Organizational Knowledge Is Stored



Note: Showing top eight responses
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

Connecting AI Systems To Organizational Knowledge Improves AI Usefulness

The real value of AI in the enterprise is unlocked when it can access and reason over the full breadth of an organization's knowledge — not just data siloed within individual applications. To make this possible, organizations need high-quality, well-labeled, and semantically consistent knowledge. For example, concepts such as "order" or "revenue" use the same labels and structures across systems and datasets.[3] We found that:

- **Good organizational knowledge is critical for improving AI usefulness.** Surveyed decision-makers recognized that enhancing knowledge accessibility is important for ensuring AI quality. In fact, more than eight in 10 said their organization's ability to improve AI outputs, scale across the enterprise, and use AI as a competitive advantage requires unifying knowledge and reducing data silos (see Figure 6). Achieving this requires systems that can access and reason over file shares, productivity tools, software development tooling, project management tools, and more. To ensure accuracy, recency, and fast retrieval, these systems must operate on a continuously updated data layer that captures new knowledge and evolving context in real time.

- **Manual knowledge maintenance isn't enough.** Organizations must fundamentally shift how they maintain knowledge. Knowledge can't be

FIGURE 6

Improvements Needed To Make AI Useful

89%

My organization's ability to scale AI depends on its ability to **unify internal and external organizational knowledge sources in a consistent format**

89%

My organization's ability to use AI as a competitive advantage hinges on its ability to **improve the organizational knowledge data needed to drive model outputs**

85%

My organization needs to **reduce fragmented and siloed data to enable AI to deliver higher-value outputs**

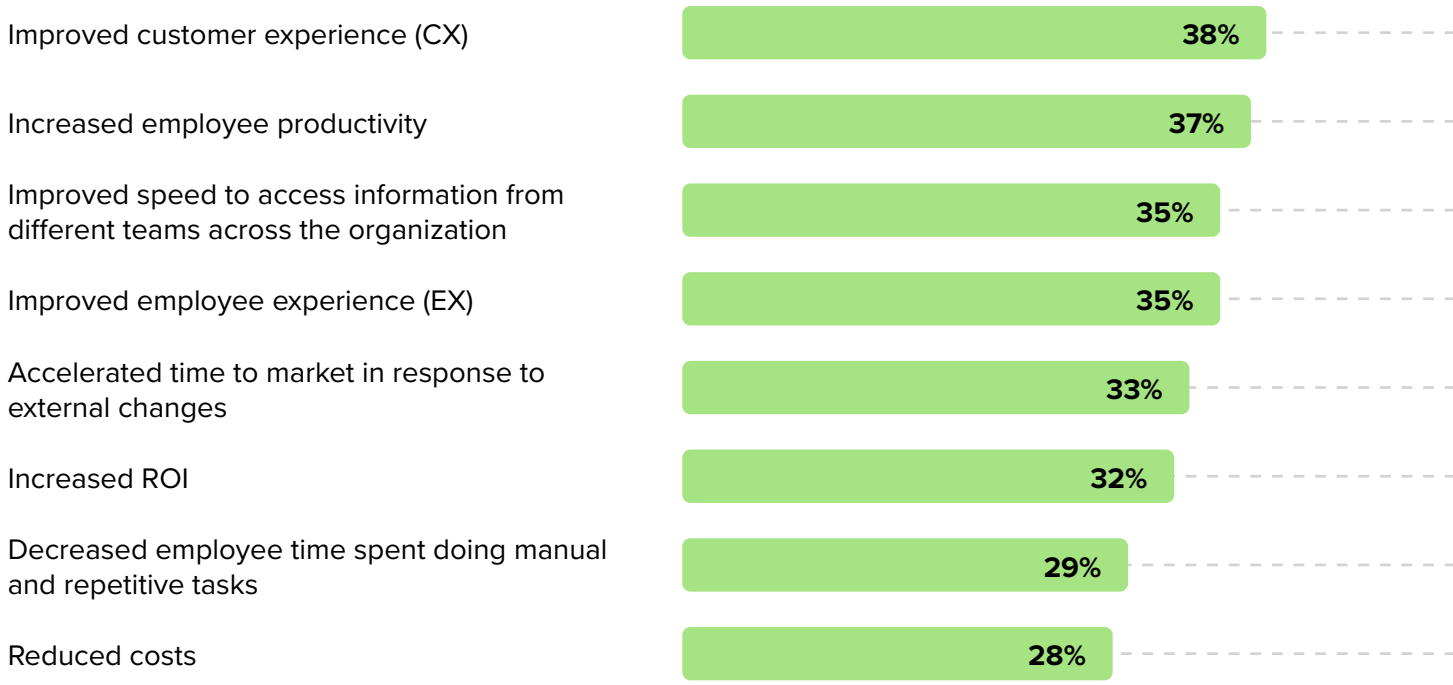
Note: Showing top three responses
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

a static repository that depends on humans doing their best. Keeping knowledge static leads to cherry-picked, manually curated, siloed information that can't keep up with change. Knowledge bases need to function as living, comprehensive, accessible, and continuously learning systems. To make this a reality, automated systems are now being used to create and maintain the very knowledge bases that enterprise AI systems will rely on as key data layers.[4]

- **Connecting AI systems with organizational knowledge provides newfound business value.** Integrating organizational knowledge into AI models is a catalyst for unlocking the real value of AI. Surveyed decision-makers indicated that their organizations would see the greatest benefits in improved customer experience, increased employee productivity, faster access to information across teams, and improved employee experience (see Figure 7).

FIGURE 7

Top Benefits Of Improving Organizational Knowledge



Note: Showing top eight responses
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

Knowledge Graphs Transform AI's Ability To Reason Over All Organizational Knowledge

The journey toward better data and organizational knowledge is not new. What's different now is the opportunity to leverage AI on top of a knowledge graph-powered data platform. Knowledge graphs provide organizations with the foundation of knowledge that employees and systems need to more effectively do their jobs. AI systems need to understand relationships, team workflows, and organizational knowledge to answer employee questions (e.g., "What collaborators worked on a project with me," or "What scoping document was the final one we sent to the client?"). Together, these enable smarter, more adaptive automation. We found that:

- **Knowledge graphs improve accessibility for AI systems.** A knowledge graph enables a unified, AI-ready data layer to break down knowledge silos. This makes it possible to surface the connections, expertise, and context — which would otherwise remain hidden —needed to make AI useful. Expected benefits from implementing a knowledge graph included improved intra- and interplatform data unification, more informed employees, improved cross-team automation, and accelerated decision-making (see Figure 8).

A knowledge graph is an interconnected knowledge base that uses flexible links (edges) between entities (nodes) to define relationships.

For example, an "employee" could be linked to projects, role, communication tools, and more. The graph would enable a search for all of communications related to a given project and its associated developers without requiring this information to be stored in a single location.

FIGURE 8

Top Benefits Of Knowledge Graph Implementation

Note: Showing top eight responses
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

- **Despite the ability to transform AI effectiveness, knowledge graphs remain a black hole for many organizations.** Before defining a knowledge graph in our survey, we asked decision-makers to indicate how familiar they were with the concept. Just 34% of decision-makers indicated they have an in-depth understanding of what knowledge graphs are and how they can be used. Even though knowledge graphs are not a new technology, many organizations lack a full understanding of their capabilities and benefits, especially the value and increased AI effectiveness they can help drive by supplying AI agents with missing contextual data.

EMBEDDED KNOWLEDGE GRAPH-POWERED PRODUCTS PROVIDE THE FOUNDATION NEEDED FOR ENTERPRISE AI SYSTEMS

Nine in 10 decision-makers reported their organization would be interested or very interested in knowledge graph-powered products for the ability to use AI for more robust applications and use cases (see Figure 9).

Augmenting AI with an AI-embedded knowledge graph-powered product, such as enterprise knowledge and collaboration system, offers a fast, easy way for organizations to improve knowledge accessibility while avoiding the challenges of building and maintaining their own knowledge graphs. The result is amplified value from both existing data stewardship investments and platforms that already rely on knowledge graphs as a foundational structure. We found that:

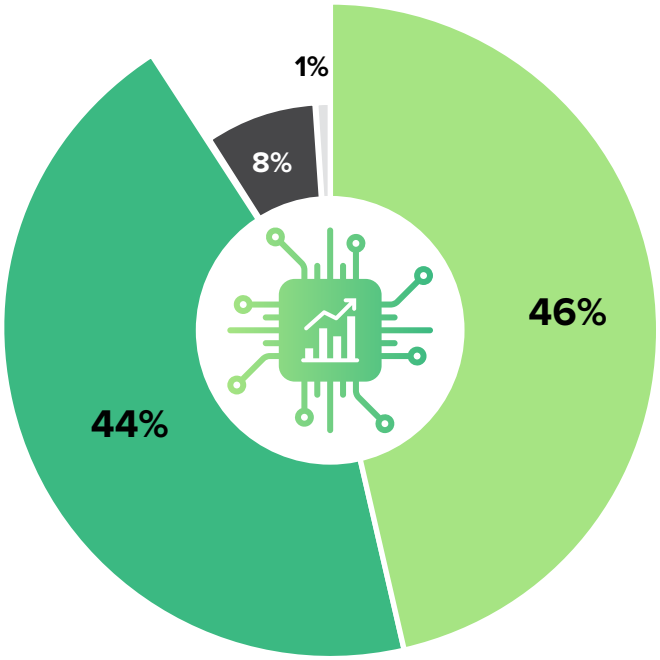
- **Partnering with strategic tech providers top adoption plans.** Despite interest in the technology, most organizations lack required skill sets to make and maintain graphs capable of representing the breadth of enterprise knowledge. More than half (51%) of decision-makers indicated partnering with a strategic tech provider was their top priority for improving organizational knowledge (see Figure 10).

- **Using embedded knowledge graph-powered products from strategic tech providers address the challenges of building from scratch.** Building a knowledge graph from scratch is often resource intensive. Using a partner allows organizations to leverage an existing ontological map and simplify data hygiene. Instead of having to agree on the definition of a specific phrase to utilize the data (e.g., is “works with” defined based on reporting line or actual project collaboration?), the knowledge graph can simply be consumed without the accompanying philosophical debate. Using a tech provider with a knowledge graph embedded into an AI data platform creates a more effective enterprise knowledge and search system. This helps organizations decrease technical debt and benefit from economies of scale.[5]

FIGURE 9

Interest In Knowledge Graph-Powered Products If They Improve More Robust AI Use

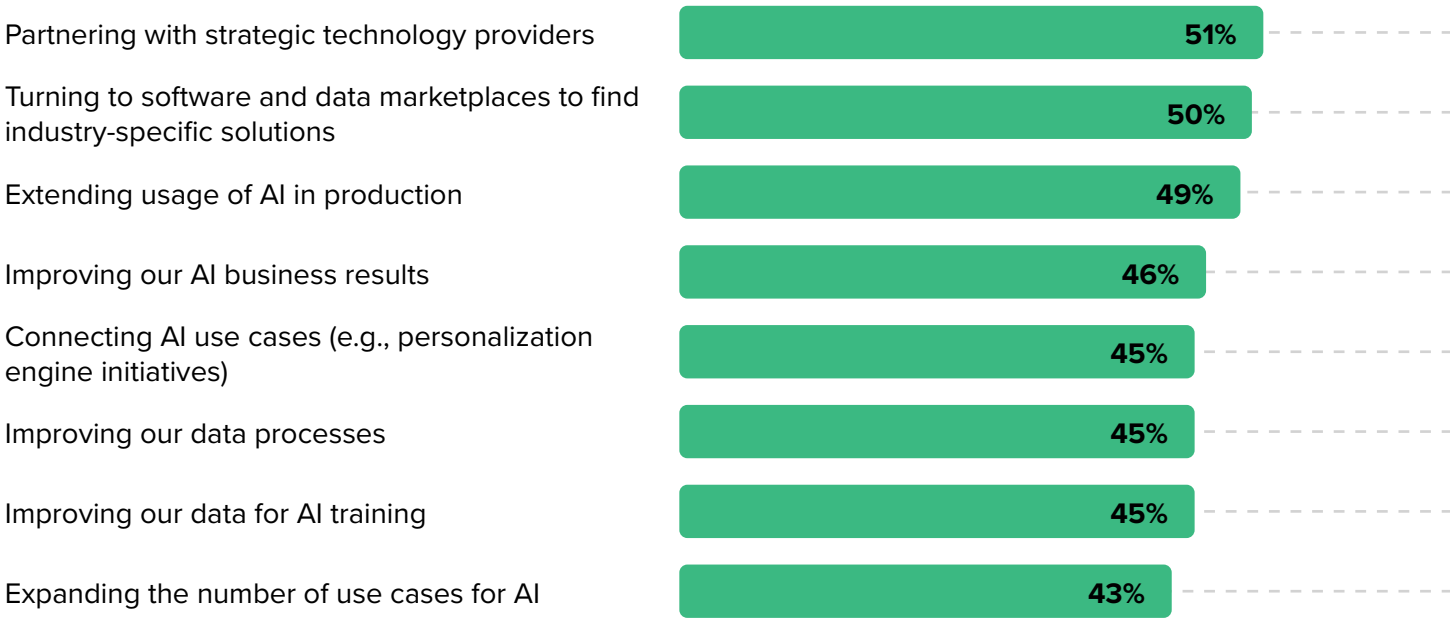
- Very interested
- Interested
- Somewhat interested
- Not very interested
- Not at all interested
- My organization is already using knowledge-graph powered products to improve its use of AI



Note: Percentages may not total 100 due to rounding.
Base: 275 AI decision-makers in enterprise tech, data/analytics, and strategic software investments
Source: Forrester's Q3 2025 Organizational Knowledge Management Survey [E-65178]

FIGURE 10

Priorities For Improving Organizational Knowledge



Note: Showing top eight responses
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Key Recommendations

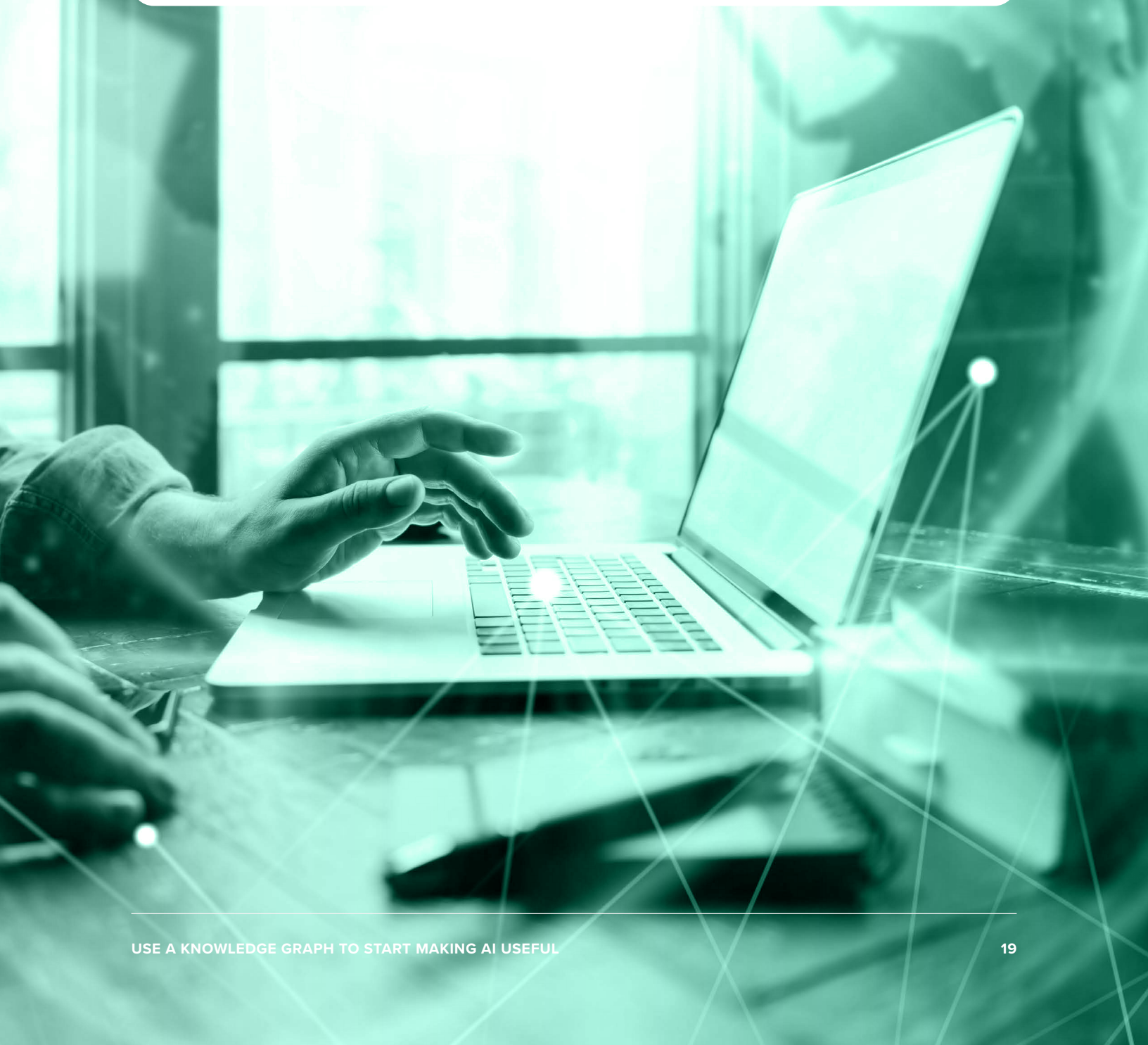
Investing in knowledge-graph powered technology solutions presents a significant — and fast-growing — opportunity to harness the true power of enterprise AI for work. Forrester's in-depth survey of 275 AI decision-makers yielded several important recommendations:

Embrace AI data platforms underpinned by knowledge graphs to ground AI in your business context. The most important step you can take in improving AI relevancy is simply providing AI tools with an effective data index. AI-ready data platforms are growing in importance, and knowledge graphs provide their essential cypher layer to connect data, relationships, and business context. In addition to making it easier for employees to get their questions answered (like searching "open tasks for Acme"), knowledge graphs provide the same benefit to AI tools. Prioritizing products that have AI-ready data platforms with knowledge graphs as a foundational data layer (or compatibility with existing graphs) provides a critical data foundation.

Invest in cross-ecosystem graphs. Organizational knowledge (and work) is involuntarily decentralized today. For any data layer to serve as a foundation for context-aware AI systems, it must be able to seamlessly connect insights and information from all tools that employees use in their day-to-day (for example, with Acme open tasks, looking into project management, collaborative work management [CWM], CRM and even email tools). Invest in tool ecosystems that graphs can effectively bridge across multiple vendor ecosystems. Once online, ensure you are enabling the required connections to the graph. Vendors who can serve as this trusted partner and who can assist with this ongoing integration must be prioritized.

Invest in making knowledge management a shared (and easy) responsibility. While knowledge graphs should provide the key connective tissue for organizational knowledge, it pays to make sure that what its connecting is right in the first place. Most organizations today suffer from incomplete, disorganized, and out-of-date formal knowledge. Part of this will

be solved by graphs, and part of it needs humans in the loop to help fix (for example, answering, “What is our strategic priority with the Acme account?”). Two changes are required: 1) Build a knowledge management practice to evaluate both where information lives and the state of it, and 2) use this practice to help your organization change knowledge management from a silo to a shared sport. For example, building collaborative knowledge review into not just a valued practice but also embedding responsibilities into team goals.



Appendix A: Methodology

In this study, Forrester conducted an online survey of 275 AI decision-makers at organizations across industries in North America, Europe, and APAC to evaluate how the enterprise AI systems that organizations have implemented today for employees are able to access organizational knowledge, and how knowledge graph-powered solutions can help with this. Survey participants included decision-makers in enterprise technology/software development, data and analytics, and strategic software investments. Questions provided to the participants asked how their AI systems use organizational knowledge today, the challenges they face with using AI systems to access organizational knowledge, and what impact knowledge graph-powered solutions can have on improving AI outcomes. Respondents were offered a small incentive as a thank-you for time spent on the survey. The study was completed in September 2025.

Appendix B: Demographics

GEOGRAPHY	
North America	**41%**
Europe	**39%**
APAC	**20%**

INDUSTRY (TOP 5)	
Tech/tech services	**15%**
Manufacturing/materials	**14%**
Retail	**13%**
CPG	**11%**
Financial services/insurance	**10%**

ROLE	
Enterprise technology/software development	**83%**
Data and analytics	**80%**
Strategic software investments	**66%**

COMPANY SIZE	
5,000 to 7,999 FTEs	**29%**
7,500 to 9,999 FTEs	**31%**
10,000 to 14,999 FTEs	**23%**
15,000 or more FTEs	**17%**

TITLE	
C-level	**37%**
Vice president	**36%**
Director	**23%**
Manager	**4%**

Note: Percentages may not total 100 due to rounding.

Appendix C: Supplemental Material

RELATED FORRESTER RESEARCH

Tech Exec Primer To The Symbiotic Relationship Between Knowledge Graphs And GenAI, Forrester Research, Inc., August 2, 2024.

Key Capabilities Of A Modern Data And AI Platform, Forrester Research, Inc., November 4, 2025.

Move Beyond Agile Knowledge Management With Generative AI, Forrester Research, Inc., December 12, 2024.

Use Knowledge Graphs To Manage Knowledge Instead Of Data, Forrester Research, Inc., April 25, 2023.

Turn Your Proprietary Knowledge Into AI Advantage, Forrester Research, Inc., December 23, 2024.

The Forrester Data, AI, And Analytics Architecture Model, Forrester Research, Inc., October 6, 2025.

Align AI Strategy And Value To Maximize Investments, Forrester Research, Inc., July 2, 2025.

Ground Your Workforce AI Strategy In Human Experience, Forrester Research, Inc., March 6, 2025.

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Indranil Bandyopadhyay, Generative AI And Knowledge Graphs: A Match Made In Heaven, Forrester Blogs.

Charles Betz, AI Wakes The Sleeping Giant: Continuous Improvement Will Finally Fulfill Its Promise, Forrester Blogs.

Appendix D: Endnotes

[1] Source: Align AI Strategy And Value To Maximize Investments, Forrester Research, Inc., July 2, 2025.

[2] Source: Key Capabilities Of A Modern Data And AI Platform, Forrester Research, Inc., November 4, 2025.

[3] Source: Tech Exec Primer To The Symbiotic Relationship Between Knowledge Graphs And GenAI, Forrester Research, Inc., August 2, 2024.

[4] Source: Charles Betz, AI Wakes The Sleeping Giant: Continuous Improvement Will Finally Fulfill Its Promise, Forrester Blogs.

[5] Source: Tech Exec Primer To The Symbiotic Relationship Between Knowledge Graphs And GenAI, Forrester Research, Inc., August 2, 2024.

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